RETURN OF THE SPARROW

Once a fairly common sight, the urban house sparrow is slowly hopping back into our backyards



Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

HOUSE SPARROW
Passer domesticus

IN the early 2000s, the sparrow population began to decline alarmingly in India, by almost 70 per cent in certain areas. Among the reasons for decline was the lack of nesting sites in concrete buildings, disappearing kitchen gardens, competition for food from pigeons, electromagnetic radiation from mobile towers and disturbances from traffic noise and pollution.

However, the State of India's Birds 2020 report noticed the sparrow population becoming stable in the past 25 years. The revival of the bird owes a lot to the several micro-conservation efforts. In Delhi, for example, the Eco Roots Foundation has put out 700,000 nests for the birds. The bird was adopted as the state bird in 2012 and March 20 is celebrated as World Sparrow Day. Many people are also returning to feeding the birds with affordable bird feeders online.



"Compared to 120–140 for humans, birds have a heart rate of 230–240. So, they tend to bleed more readily, and get so scared that they go into shocks"

– DR SHIWANI TANDEL
Phoenix Veterinary Speciality, Mumbai

Pradesh, where its numbers have grown from 700 individuals in 2013 to more than 2,500 now.

Likewise, experts are hailing the return of the Amur falcon as a success. The start of the winter season brings these birds from Mongolia to northeast India in large numbers. Poaching and the illegal wildlife trade had led to a sharp decline. Steep penalties and educating local communities have slowly seen the numbers revive. And just last November, four years after the release of the threatened Cheer pheasant (*Catreus wallichii*) in Himachal Pradesh, the project notched its first milestone as two breeding pairs were observed in Seri village. With only 2,700 of these speckled birds left in the subcontinent, such moments are critical for their survival. In Bihar, too, efforts by individuals and the forest department have resulted in the number of Greater adjutant (*Leptoptilos dubius*) storks crossing 600 in just the Kadwa-Kosi riverine belt. India now has 90 per cent of the bird's population.

In Gurugram, a local community-driven effort by IamGurgaon is working towards the greater avian good by planting native trees all across the Aravalli Biodiversity Park. It now has more than 200 species. "We don't use pesticides and ensure there is good, naturally-suited tree cover," says co-founder Latika Thukral. "This brought back insects and, eventually, the birds."

DELHI, MEANWHILE, IS WELCOMING the chirpy house sparrow (see *Return of the Sparrow*). "It went away because we closed our houses and hearts to them," says Rakesh Khatri, founder, Eco Roots Foundation. The nests they make out of natural material like jute for sparrows have seen an adoption rate of 90 per cent.

More than governments and specialist communities, however, it is ordinary citizens whose awareness can be critical to avian survival. Humans need to ask themselves a pertinent moral question: are we the only species that deserves to be on this planet? "We have a moral and ethical obligation to protect birds," says Santharam. "If not only because we have inherited this planet and must make space for all life, then also because of how much we enjoy birds—their song, their colours."

Their aural and visual pleasure apart, birds leave an impact on the planet in countless other ways. At the Thane creek, the treated wastewater, rich in organic matter, is helping the fish, and even the mangroves, thrive. The birds, in turn, forage on the produce here. "We don't know what will happen if there are no birds in this well-established order of nature," says Prabhu. For, not only do birds help other elements in an ecosystem, they also help one another. Woodpeckers, for example, excavate fresh cavities every year, which, in turn, provide nesting niches for other cavity-nesters such as owls and hornbills. If woodpeckers go, so will the other two. There are several such bird-to-bird linkages we may not discover until it's too late. "It is terribly important to have a diversity of birds," says Santharam. "A world with only rock pigeons and crows will mean the loss of many important habitats key to human survival." Life as you know it will change under a sky without birds. ■

–with Rahul Noronha